

QUESTION 1

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Architect Mireya Solano is best known for designing sustainable housing in arid climates. Her early work focused on passive cooling techniques that reduced energy consumption by as much as 60 percent. More recently, Solano has expanded her practice to include large-scale urban planning projects that incorporate green corridors and rainwater harvesting infrastructure, earning her international recognition as a leader in climate-adaptive design.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It presents an architect's design philosophy, provides examples of projects that applied it, and then evaluates the philosophy's influence on the wider field.

B: It introduces a figure, describes an early focus of her career, and then notes how her work has since broadened.

C: It identifies a challenge in sustainable architecture, describes one architect's attempt to address it, and then assesses the attempt's effectiveness.

D: It traces the development of a building technique, explains the engineering principles behind it, and then discusses its adoption in multiple regions.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Count the beats: introduce Solano -> describe early work (passive cooling) -> note broadening (urban planning). That's a biographical arc, not a problem-solution or technique history. Trick: if the text names a person first, check for a career trajectory structure before anything else.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 2

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: For decades, marine biologists assumed that deep-sea corals grew at negligibly slow rates and therefore contributed little to reef formation. However, a 2019 study led by oceanographer Elias Varga demonstrated that certain cold-water coral species can grow up to 15 millimeters per year under nutrient-rich conditions. This finding suggests that deep-sea corals may play a larger role in oceanic ecosystems than scientists previously recognized.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It describes an earlier assumption, introduces a study that challenges it, and then notes the broader implication of the study's findings.

B: It presents a researcher's hypothesis about coral growth, describes the experiment used to test it, and then acknowledges a limitation of the experimental method.

C: It introduces a marine ecosystem, explains the role of a particular species within it, and then describes how that role has changed over time due to environmental factors.

D: It identifies a gap in scientific knowledge, explains how a researcher investigated the gap, and then presents two competing interpretations of the results.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Spot the pivot word "However" -- it signals old view -> new evidence. The final sentence ("This finding suggests") delivers the implication. Trick: "However" between two claims almost always means assumption -> challenge -> implication.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 3

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The Aymara people of the Andes have a distinctive conceptualization of time. Unlike many cultures, which associate the future with what lies ahead and the past with what lies behind, the Aymara place the past in front of them -- because it has been seen -- and the future behind them -- because it remains unseen. Linguist Rafael Nunez documented this by analyzing Aymara speakers' gestures: when discussing past events, speakers consistently gestured forward, and when discussing future events, they gestured behind themselves.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It introduces a linguist's research methodology, evaluates the strength of the evidence the research produced, and then discusses the broader implications for cognitive science.

B: It explains a theory of how language shapes perception, provides evidence from multiple cultures that supports the theory, and then notes an exception that complicates it.

C: It describes a widespread assumption about how humans conceptualize time, traces the assumption to its historical origins, and then critiques the assumption's validity.

D: It identifies a cultural practice, contrasts it with a more common convention, and then describes evidence supporting the observation.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: The text's real subject is the Aymara concept of time, not Nunez's career. Structure: unique practice -> contrast with the norm -> gestural evidence. Trick: ask "what is this text ABOUT?" If the answer is a phenomenon and not a person, it's not a researcher profile -- even if a researcher is named.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 4

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Cellist Nadia Ferreira gained early acclaim performing classical repertoire with major orchestras. Critics praised her interpretations for their emotional depth and technical precision. In 2021, however, Ferreira surprised audiences by releasing an album that blended baroque cello suites with electronic production. While some traditionalists objected, the album attracted a new, younger audience to classical music.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It traces a musician's artistic development from early influences through a mature style, and then evaluates the lasting significance of her contribution to the genre.

B: It describes a controversy within a musical genre, presents arguments from both supporters and critics, and then proposes a resolution to the disagreement.

C: It introduces a musician, describes her initial reputation, and then discusses a departure from that reputation and its mixed reception.

D: It presents a musician's early career, attributes her success to a specific technique, and then explains how that technique was adopted by other artists in the field.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: "However" signals the shift from established reputation to surprising departure. The text covers only two phases (early acclaim -> genre-blending album), not a full career. Trick: if the passage says "however" mid-text about a person, look for "reputation -> departure" rather than "entire career chronology."

END QUESTION

QUESTION 5

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Many species of firefly produce bioluminescent flashes to attract mates. Each species has a distinct flash pattern -- varying in duration, interval, and color -- that helps individuals identify members of their own species in the dark. Researchers at the Tallahassee Entomological Institute have cataloged over forty unique flash patterns among firefly species in the southeastern United States alone.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It describes a behavior, explains the purpose and variation of that behavior, and then provides a detail that illustrates the extent of the variation.

B: It introduces a natural phenomenon, proposes a hypothesis about its evolutionary origin, and then describes an experiment designed to test that hypothesis.

C: It identifies a species' survival strategy, contrasts the strategy with those of related species, and then evaluates which strategy is most effective.

D: It presents a biological observation, explains the methodology researchers used to study it, and then discusses how the observation revised a previous classification.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The final sentence ("over forty unique flash patterns") is a quantitative detail that illustrates the scope of variation described in the middle. Trick: cataloging = observational record, not hypothesis testing. If no experiment is described, eliminate options that mention testing or experiments.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 6

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: In her 2018 study, sociologist Priya Chandran surveyed over 3,000 remote workers across twelve countries about their sense of professional belonging. Chandran found that remote workers who participated in at least one virtual social event per week reported significantly higher levels of team cohesion than those who did not. She concluded that informal digital interactions can partially offset the isolation that remote work often produces.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It argues that a workplace trend produces negative consequences, presents data supporting the argument, and then recommends a policy to mitigate those consequences.

B: It introduces a sociological theory about remote work, describes a study that contradicts the theory, and then evaluates whether the theory should be revised.

C: It compares workplace satisfaction across two employment models, identifies the factor most responsible for the difference, and then predicts how that factor will evolve.

D: It describes a study's methodology, presents a key finding, and then states the researcher's conclusion based on that finding.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: This is a classic research-summary structure: survey design -> result -> takeaway. The text reports a finding rather than arguing for a policy. Trick: when a passage opens with a study's details (sample size, countries), expect methodology -> finding -> conclusion.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 7

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The ceramic traditions of the ancient Pueblo peoples of the American Southwest are notable for their geometric painted designs. These designs were not merely decorative: archaeologist Sandra Kinley has argued that specific motifs corresponded to clan identities, serving as markers of social affiliation during trade and ceremonial gatherings. Kinley's interpretation is supported by the observation that vessels bearing identical motifs are consistently found within the same residential clusters at excavated sites.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It catalogs the decorative motifs found at an archaeological site, classifies each motif by historical period, and then challenges a previous scholar's interpretation of their significance.

B: It describes an artistic tradition, presents a scholar's interpretation of its social function, and then cites evidence supporting that interpretation.

C: It traces the evolution of a craft technique across several centuries, explains why the technique declined, and then describes efforts to revive it in contemporary practice.

D: It introduces an archaeological discovery, compares it with findings from a related site, and then argues that both sites were part of the same cultural network.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Tradition -> interpretation -> evidence is a common DSAT structure for humanities passages. The excavation data supports Kinley's claim -- it doesn't challenge a previous scholar. Trick: when a scholar's name appears with "argued" or "interpretation," the text is probably building toward supporting evidence, not starting a debate.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 8

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Wind power is one of the fastest-growing sources of renewable energy worldwide. Turbines convert kinetic energy from wind into electricity, and modern designs can generate power at wind speeds as low as 3 meters per second. Denmark, a pioneer in wind energy, now derives more than half of its electricity from wind turbines, demonstrating that wind power can serve as a primary energy source for an entire nation.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It presents a technological innovation, attributes its development to a specific country, and then argues that the innovation should be adopted more widely.

B: It identifies a limitation of a current energy source, explains the engineering solution that overcame the limitation, and then predicts the technology's future growth.

C: It introduces an energy source, explains how it works, and then provides a real-world example that demonstrates its viability.

D: It compares two approaches to generating renewable energy, evaluates the cost-effectiveness of each, and then recommends the approach that is more scalable.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: What is it? -> How does it work? -> Real example. The text is purely expository -- it informs without arguing for or against a policy. Trick: Denmark is an example illustrating viability, not an argument for adoption. If the text states facts without "should" or "must," it's informational, not argumentative.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 9

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Literary scholars have long debated whether the anonymous medieval poem *The Seafarer* should be read as a literal account of maritime hardship or as an allegory for spiritual pilgrimage. Those favoring the literal reading point to the poem's vivid descriptions of icy seas and physical suffering, while proponents of the allegorical interpretation emphasize the poem's closing passages, which shift from oceanic imagery to meditations on divine grace. More recently, critic Helena Voss has proposed that these readings need not be mutually exclusive: the poem's power, she argues, derives precisely from the tension between bodily experience and spiritual aspiration.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It introduces a poem, describes the historical context in which it was composed, and then argues that understanding that context is essential to interpreting the poem correctly.

B: It outlines a scholarly disagreement, summarizes the evidence each side cites, and then presents a position that synthesizes elements of both sides.

C: It presents a traditional interpretation of a literary work, introduces a critic who rejects that interpretation entirely, and then evaluates which reading is better supported by the text.

D: It describes two literary techniques used in a poem, explains the effect each technique produces, and then argues that one technique is more central to the poem's meaning than the other.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: "Need not be mutually exclusive" is the synthesis signal -- Voss embraces both readings rather than rejecting either. Trick: if the final scholar says "both" or "tension between," the structure is debate -> evidence -> synthesis, not debate -> winner.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 10

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Economists have traditionally measured national prosperity using gross domestic product, a metric that aggregates the market value of goods and services produced within a country's borders. Critics, however, note that GDP fails to capture many factors that affect citizens' quality of life, such as income inequality, environmental degradation, and access to healthcare. In response, several international organizations have developed alternative indices -- such as the Inclusive Development Index and the Human Development Index -- that incorporate these broader dimensions of well-being alongside economic output.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It compares two approaches to measuring national prosperity, evaluates the strengths and weaknesses of each, and then recommends a hybrid approach that incorporates elements of both.

B: It introduces an economic indicator, explains the historical circumstances under which it was developed, and then argues that the indicator has outlived its usefulness.

C: It presents a critique of a standard economic measure, defends the measure against the critique by citing recent data, and then proposes modifications to improve the measure's accuracy.

D: It defines a widely used metric, identifies limitations of that metric, and then describes efforts to address those limitations through alternative measures.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Define -> criticize -> alternative. The alternatives (IDI, HDI) are presented as complements that address gaps, not replacements that render GDP useless. Trick: "In response" signals that what follows addresses the limitations just named -- match that three-beat flow.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 11

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The fruit fly *Drosophila melanogaster* has been a cornerstone of genetic research since Thomas Hunt Morgan's early twentieth-century experiments. Because fruit flies reproduce quickly and share a surprising number of genes with humans, they allow scientists to study processes like cell division and disease susceptibility in compressed timeframes. Recent advances in CRISPR gene-editing technology have made fruit flies even more valuable: researchers can now introduce precise genetic modifications and observe their effects within a single generation, accelerating the pace of discovery.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A: It presents a scientific breakthrough, explains the theory behind it, and then discusses the ethical implications that followed from the breakthrough's applications.
- B: It traces the history of a research methodology, identifies the point at which it became widely adopted, and then predicts how it will evolve as new tools become available.
- C: It compares two model organisms used in genetic research, explains the advantages of each, and then argues that one has been unfairly overlooked in recent studies.
- D: It introduces a research organism, explains why it is useful for scientific study, and then describes how a new technology has increased its value as a research tool.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Useful organism -> reasons why -> new tech makes it more useful. CRISPR is mentioned for its utility, not for ethical concerns. Trick: the word "even more valuable" tells you the third beat amplifies the second -- same direction, not a new controversy.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 12

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Philosopher Martha Nussbaum has argued that literature cultivates moral imagination by requiring readers to inhabit perspectives radically different from their own. Reading a novel about a refugee's journey, for example, may deepen a reader's empathy for displaced populations in ways that statistics and policy reports cannot. Nussbaum acknowledges, however, that literature alone is insufficient for ethical development; without critical reflection on what one reads, the emotional responses that literature elicits may reinforce existing biases rather than challenge them.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It summarizes a debate among philosophers about literature's role in education, presents the strongest argument on each side, and then evaluates which position is better supported.

B: It introduces a theory of ethical development, explains how the theory has been applied in educational settings, and then describes empirical evidence that confirms the theory's predictions.

C: It presents a philosopher's claim about literature's moral value, illustrates the claim with an example, and then introduces a qualification that limits the claim.

D: It describes a shortcoming in how literature is taught, proposes a specific pedagogical reform, and then anticipates objections to the proposed reform.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Claim -> example -> "however" caveat. Only one philosopher is discussed, so "debate among philosophers" is wrong. The "however" introduces a limitation, not a reversal. Trick: when the same thinker says "however," it's a self-qualification, not a debate with another scholar.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 13

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Urban heat islands -- areas within cities that experience significantly higher temperatures than surrounding rural regions -- pose growing public health risks as global temperatures rise. The primary driver of urban heat islands is the replacement of vegetation with impervious surfaces such as asphalt and concrete, which absorb and retain solar energy. While strategies like increasing tree canopy cover and installing reflective roofing materials have shown promise in reducing surface temperatures, implementation remains uneven: wealthier neighborhoods tend to receive green infrastructure investments at higher rates than lower-income communities do.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It defines an environmental concept, argues that the concept has been overstated in popular media, and then calls for a more measured public response to the issue.

B: It identifies a phenomenon, explains its primary cause, acknowledges potential solutions, and then notes an inequity in how those solutions are applied.

C: It describes a public health risk, traces the risk to individual behavioral choices, and then evaluates the effectiveness of a government program designed to reduce the risk.

D: It compares temperature patterns in two types of environments, proposes an explanation for the difference, and then describes a study that tested the proposed explanation.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: This is a four-beat structure: what -> why -> fix -> but uneven. Count every beat and match the option that captures all of them. Trick: when a passage ends on an inequity or caveat, options that stop at three beats are incomplete -- look for the four-beat option.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 14

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Pianist Dmitri Kovalenko emigrated from Kyiv to Chicago in 1962 and began recording small-ensemble jazz sessions that blended Eastern European folk harmonies with bebop improvisation. Although Kovalenko's initial recordings received little airplay, they circulated widely among jazz musicians, who admired his unconventional use of dissonance. By the mid-1970s, Kovalenko's approach had influenced a generation of avant-garde jazz composers, and music historians now regard him as a pivotal figure in the genre's evolution.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It presents a contrast between commercial reception and peer influence that sets up the text's later discussion of lasting impact.

B: It provides evidence that Kovalenko's recordings were artistically flawed, which explains why critics initially dismissed his work.

C: It establishes that Kovalenko's work was popular with general audiences, which makes his later shift to avant-garde composition more surprising.

D: It explains the specific musical technique that Kovalenko developed, which the text later credits as his primary contribution to jazz.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The underlined portion contains a contrast: little airplay BUT wide circulation among musicians. This sets up the conclusion about lasting influence. Trick: for function questions, ask "what role does this play in the argument?" not "what does it literally say?" A contrast that precedes a conclusion about impact = setup.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 15

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: <u>Honeybees are widely regarded as the most important insect pollinators of agricultural crops.</u> However, a meta-analysis by entomologist Clara Reyes examined pollination data from 41 countries and found that wild bee species collectively pollinated a greater variety of crop plants than managed honeybee colonies did. Reyes's findings suggest that conservation of wild bee habitats may be at least as critical to global food security as the maintenance of commercial honeybee populations.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It presents the main conclusion that the meta-analysis ultimately confirms with additional supporting data.
- B: It identifies a methodological limitation that weakens the reliability of the study's findings.
- C: It provides necessary background on pollination biology that helps the reader understand the study's research design.
- D: It establishes a widely held view that the study discussed in the text calls into question.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: "Widely regarded" + "However" right after = a common view is about to be challenged. The underlined sentence isn't the study's conclusion -- it's the assumption the study overturns. Trick: when the underlined portion uses language like "widely regarded," "traditionally believed," or "long assumed," its function is almost always to set up a challenge.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 16

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Restorers working on a fifteenth-century altarpiece in a Florentine chapel discovered, beneath layers of later overpainting, a richly detailed landscape that had been hidden for centuries. Chemical analysis of the pigments revealed that the original artist had used an unusually expensive ultramarine blue derived from lapis lazuli -- a material typically reserved for the most prestigious commissions. This finding prompted art historians to reconsider the altarpiece's provenance, suggesting it may have been commissioned by a wealthier patron than previously believed.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It introduces an artistic controversy about the altarpiece's attribution, evaluates the evidence on each side, and then determines the most likely creator.

B: It describes a restoration technique, explains the scientific principles behind it, and then argues that the technique should be adopted more widely in art conservation.

C: It describes a discovery made during restoration, presents a material detail revealed by analysis, and then explains the historical implication that scholars drew from that detail.

D: It identifies a hidden feature in a painting, argues that the feature was deliberately concealed by a later artist, and then speculates about the motive for the concealment.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Discovery -> analysis detail -> historical implication. The text reconsiders who commissioned the work (provenance), not whether the work is genuine (authenticity). Trick: "provenance" = who ordered or owned it; "authenticity" = whether it's real. Don't confuse the two -- the text never questions whether the altarpiece is genuine.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 17

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Geographer Yuki Nakamura has documented a marked increase in the rate of mangrove forest loss along Southeast Asian coastlines between 1990 and 2010. This acceleration, Nakamura notes, coincided with a period of rapid industrialization in coastal cities. She cautions, however, that correlation alone does not establish causation, and that other factors -- including shrimp aquaculture expansion and rising sea levels -- likely contributed to mangrove decline during the same period.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It introduces a counterargument from other researchers that directly contradicts the study's central finding about mangrove loss.

B: It identifies a temporal relationship that the researcher later qualifies by acknowledging additional contributing factors.

C: It states the researcher's main conclusion, which the subsequent sentences are devoted to supporting with additional evidence.

D: It provides a specific example of the mangrove loss documented in the study, illustrating the geographic scope of the problem.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: "Coincided with" = temporal relationship, not causal conclusion. The next sentence ("however... correlation alone does not establish causation") qualifies it. Trick: "coincided with" is weaker than "caused by." When the passage adds "however" after a correlation, the underlined portion is being qualified, not supported.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 18

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Behavioral economist Tariq Osman has demonstrated that people tend to overestimate the likelihood of events that receive extensive media coverage, such as airplane crashes, while underestimating the probability of more common but less sensationalized risks, such as household falls. Osman terms this pattern 'salience bias' and argues that it distorts both individual decision-making and public policy priorities. His research has been cited by public health officials advocating for increased funding for fall-prevention programs among elderly populations.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It introduces a researcher's finding about cognitive bias, names and defines the bias, and then describes a practical application of the research.

B: It identifies a flaw in how the public perceives risk, argues that media coverage is the sole cause of the flaw, and then proposes regulations to correct media reporting.

C: It describes two types of risk and their relative frequency, explains why one type receives more public attention, and then evaluates whether the disparity in attention is justified.

D: It presents a theory of decision-making, traces the theory's development through several related studies, and then assesses whether the theory has been adequately supported.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Finding -> name/definition -> real-world use. Public health officials citing the research is a practical application, not a public health crisis narrative. Trick: when the final sentence shows someone applying the research, the structure ends with "application," not "crisis" or "policy proposal."

END QUESTION

QUESTION 19

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Art critic Tomoko Arai has challenged the conventional view that Japanese woodblock prints influenced French Impressionism in only one direction. While it is well established that artists such as Monet collected ukiyo-e prints and adopted their compositional strategies -- flattened perspective, asymmetric framing, and bold outlines -- Arai demonstrates that the exchange was reciprocal. Analyzing prints produced in Yokohama during the 1870s, she shows that Japanese printmakers incorporated Impressionist techniques, including broken brushwork and atmospheric light effects, into traditional formats. The resulting hybrid works, Arai argues, complicate the narrative of Western artistic innovation by revealing that cross-cultural influence operated simultaneously in both directions.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It introduces a widely accepted account of cross-cultural artistic exchange, explains the historical evidence on which the account rests, and then affirms the account's accuracy.

B: It describes a technique used in Japanese printmaking, identifies the specific artist who invented it, and then evaluates the technique's lasting influence on Western art.

C: It contrasts two art critics' interpretations of a particular body of work, explains how each critic uses different evidence to support her reading, and then argues that neither interpretation is fully adequate.

D: It presents a critic's challenge to a one-directional model of artistic influence by providing evidence of reciprocal exchange, and then articulates the broader implication of that evidence.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: One-way model challenged -> two-way evidence -> broader implication. Only one critic (Arai) is discussed, and she doesn't affirm the conventional view -- she overturns it. Trick: "challenged" + "reciprocal" + "complicate the narrative" = challenge -> evidence -> implication, not confirmation.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 20

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Ecologists have long relied on the principle that trophic cascades -- the indirect effects that predators exert on lower levels of a food chain -- operate primarily from the top down: removing a top predator, for instance, allows herbivore populations to expand, which in turn depletes vegetation. Recent field studies in regions where apex predators were eradicated decades ago, however, suggest that compensatory mechanisms -- such as increased competition among herbivores and shifts in plant community composition -- can partially buffer ecosystems against the expected cascade effects. This resilience, ecologists caution, is context-dependent, an assumption that may not hold in ecosystems where apex predators have been removed only recently or where biodiversity is already low.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It provides a specific example of the compensatory mechanisms that ecologists observed in the field studies.

B: It restates the central finding of the field studies in simpler terms to ensure the reader understands the key takeaway.

C: It specifies conditions under which the resilience described earlier in the text may not apply.

D: It introduces a new research question that the author suggests should be the focus of future field studies.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: "May not hold in..." = specifying when resilience doesn't apply. It doesn't restate the finding (resilience exists) -- it restricts it (resilience has limits). Trick: language like "may not hold," "except when," or "unless" signals a limiting condition, not a restatement or example.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 21

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Neuroscientist Amara Okonkwo has proposed that the sensation of aesthetic chills -- the tingling, goosebump-inducing response some people experience when listening to music -- arises from a temporary mismatch between the brain's predictive model and the actual auditory input. According to Okonkwo, the brain continuously generates expectations about upcoming musical events; when those expectations are violated in a manner that is surprising yet ultimately coherent with the piece's harmonic structure, the resulting prediction error triggers a dopaminergic reward response. Critics of this model note that chills can also occur during highly predictable musical passages, such as a familiar song's climax, suggesting that factors beyond prediction error -- including personal memories and learned associations -- may also contribute to the experience.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It introduces a neuroscientist's model of an aesthetic experience, explains the mechanism the model proposes, and then presents a criticism that suggests the model is incomplete.

B: It defines a common physiological response, traces the response to a specific neurological pathway, and then argues that the pathway has been misidentified by previous researchers.

C: It describes an experiment on music perception, reports its findings, and then evaluates whether those findings can be generalized to other forms of art.

D: It presents a psychological phenomenon, explains why it occurs in some people but not others, and then proposes a method for inducing the phenomenon reliably.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Model -> mechanism -> criticism. The critics don't say Okonkwo is wrong -- they say the model is incomplete ("factors beyond prediction error... may also contribute"). Trick: "Critics note" + "also" or "may also" = the model is incomplete, not debunked. That's a weaker criticism than "misidentified" or "refuted."

END QUESTION

QUESTION 22

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Political scientist Lucia Marin has observed that voter turnout in municipal elections across several Latin American democracies correlates not with the competitiveness of the race -- as conventional models predict -- but with the density of civic associations in a given district. Districts with more neighborhood councils, religious organizations, and cultural clubs tend to produce higher turnout even in uncontested races. Marin posits that these associations create 'mobilization networks' through which information about elections is disseminated and social pressure to vote is generated. She acknowledges, however, that her cross-sectional data cannot establish whether civic associations cause higher turnout or whether both variables are driven by a third factor, such as community socioeconomic status.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It describes a decline in civic participation, identifies the primary cause of the decline, and then evaluates the effectiveness of programs designed to reverse it.

B: It presents two competing theories of voter behavior, tests each against data from municipal elections, and then determines which theory is better supported.

C: It introduces a political reform, describes the evidence that was used to justify the reform, and then identifies an unintended consequence that has undermined the reform's effectiveness.

D: It presents a researcher's observation that challenges a conventional model, offers a proposed explanation for the observation, and then acknowledges a methodological limitation that qualifies the explanation.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Finding contradicts standard model -> proposed mechanism ("mobilization networks") -> caveat (cross-sectional data can't prove causation). The text is about what predicts turnout, not about turnout declining. Trick: when a researcher says "however, my data cannot establish," the final beat is a methodological limitation -- not a counterargument or reversal.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 23

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Literary theorist Kwame Asare has argued that contemporary book criticism would benefit from greater methodological transparency. In practice, Asare observes, most published reviews present interpretive judgments -- claims about a novel's thematic coherence, emotional authenticity, or stylistic originality -- as though they were self-evident, without making explicit the evaluative framework on which such judgments depend. By articulating their criteria openly, Asare contends, critics would not only strengthen their arguments but also invite more productive disagreement, since readers would be better positioned to identify exactly where and why their assessments diverge.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It describes the solution that Asare proposes to address the problem he has identified in contemporary criticism.
- B: It characterizes a practice that Asare identifies as problematic and that motivates his call for greater transparency.
- C: It provides a specific example of a published review that Asare analyzes to demonstrate the pattern he criticizes.
- D: It acknowledges a significant limitation of Asare's own proposed approach, conceding that full transparency may not always be achievable.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The underlined portion identifies what is wrong (hidden frameworks); the sentence AFTER it proposes how to fix it (articulate criteria openly). Trick: read the sentence that follows the underlined portion. If the next sentence starts with "By [doing X]," the underlined portion is the problem and the next sentence is the solution -- not the other way around.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 24

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Paleontologist Lena Vasquez recently reexamined a collection of fossilized trackways in Patagonia that had been attributed to a large theropod dinosaur. Using photogrammetric modeling to create three-dimensional maps of the tracks, Vasquez determined that the stride length, foot rotation, and depth of impression were more consistent with a giant ground-dwelling bird from the Cenozoic era than with any known Mesozoic theropod. If Vasquez's reinterpretation is correct, the trackways would represent the earliest evidence of avian gigantism in South America -- a conclusion that, while provocative, awaits corroboration from skeletal remains that have yet to be discovered at the site.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

A: It presents a widely accepted classification of a set of fossils, explains the evidence that supports the classification, and then defends it against a recent challenge.

B: It introduces a new research methodology, argues that the methodology is more reliable than traditional approaches, and then calls for its adoption as the standard in the field.

C: It describes a reinterpretation of fossil evidence, explains the analytical basis for the reinterpretation, states its potential significance, and then notes a gap in the supporting evidence.

D: It traces the discovery of a fossil species across multiple excavation sites, describes the initial controversy the discovery provoked, and then resolves the controversy using molecular evidence.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: New reading -> method -> importance -> but needs more proof. "Awaits corroboration" means the controversy is open, not resolved. Trick: words like "awaits," "remains to be seen," or "has yet to be" signal an evidence gap -- eliminate any option that claims the issue is settled.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 25

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Overall Structure

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Music industry analyst Jorge Fuentes has argued that streaming platforms' reliance on recommendation algorithms is homogenizing popular music. Because algorithms prioritize songs with features -- such as short intros and repetitive hooks -- that maximize listener engagement metrics, artists and producers face strong incentives to conform to a narrow sonic template. To be sure, algorithmic curation does expose listeners to artists they might never have encountered otherwise. Yet Fuentes maintains that this benefit is outweighed by the long-term cost: a reduction in the stylistic diversity that has historically driven musical innovation.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It concedes a benefit of the practice being criticized before the text reasserts that the practice's overall effect is negative.

B: It introduces the central argument of the passage, which the subsequent sentences develop with supporting evidence and examples.

C: It provides an example of a specific harm caused by algorithmic curation that the analyst considers particularly damaging to musical diversity.

D: It restates the analyst's main conclusion in more accessible language so that a general audience can understand the technical argument.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: "To be sure... Yet" is a classic concession-then-reassertion pattern on the DSAT. The underlined portion acknowledges a positive aspect before the main negative argument resumes. Trick: "To be sure" always signals a concession. The real argument comes after "Yet" or "But" or "However." The concession is never the main point.

END QUESTION